Those sweeping changes came after yet another purge within the CCP. Chen Bo, once called by Mao ‘the Sherlock Holmes’ of Yan’an’ for his able intelligence work, was accused of being a British spy and a KMT agent. In 1950, he was dismissed from his post as head of the Security Department of Guangdong province, and imprisoned for more than 20 years. Yang Fan, who had collected intelligence that facilitated the relatively peaceful takeover of Shanghai in May 1949 and later ran the city’s counterintelligence operations, was sacked in 1951 and accused of being a KMT agent. Yang was imprisoned in 1955 and not released until 1978. Pan Hannian, a former CCP deputy intelligence chief who had led operations against the KMT in the early 1930s and against the Japanese during World War II, was arrested in 1955 and charged with having been a spy for the KMT as well as for Japan. He died in prison in 1977. According to Chambers, ‘[Pan] was the headline victim of an intelligence purge in which 800–1,000 cadres received compulsory job transfers, demotions or lengthy prison sentences, some committing suicide to avoid interrogation’.[49]

Perhaps fearing repercussions from other senior Party cadres he had purged in 1943 but which had then returned to power, Kang withdrew from public life after the Communist victory in the Chinese civil war, which enabled him to stay clear of the power struggles of the early 1950s. But then he re-appeared in 1956, now in charge of ‘foreign relations’, which meant meeting representatives of foreign fraternal parties and going on overseas trips. His first foreign visit was to East Germany in March as head of the Chinese delegation to the Third Congress of the ruling Socialist Unity Party. At home in China, he arranged to travel frequently with Mao, which gave him renewed access to the Chairman. Then, Kang became, of course, one of the masterminds and most brutal inquisitors of the Cultural Revolution in the 1960s and 1970s. He even led a thorough purge of the ID/CCP, which in March 1967 was placed under military control before being absorbed by China’s military intelligence apparatus two years later.

Chaos reigned as Kang went berserk, accusing people of past and present ‘crimes’ such as being members of a ‘Japanese Special Service Clique’ during the 1937–45 war with Japan, and, in more recent years, of the ‘Soviet Revisionist Special Service Group’ or the ‘Shielding the Hidden US-Chiang Kai-shek Organisation Group’.[50] The then ID/CCP de facto chief Zou Dapeng committed suicide with his wife, herself a senior intelligence operative, rather than having to face the kind of interrogation